

Ultimate Chess

Rulebook

For players who already know standard chess

Overview

Ultimate Chess is a variant of standard chess in which captures are never automatic. Instead, every attempted capture triggers a card battle — a round of War played with a standard deck. Luck, timing, and risk management layer on top of positional chess strategy.

This rulebook covers only the rules that differ from standard chess. Piece movement, turn order, castling, en passant, and promotion follow standard chess rules unless otherwise noted here.

Note: Both players need a full standard deck of cards including both Jokers before the game begins. Alternatively, see Dice Variant for a card-free option.

Components

- Standard chess set (board and all pieces)
- Two standard 52-card decks with Jokers — one per player

Each player owns and shuffles their own deck. Both decks are independent; you always draw from and play cards from your own deck.

Core Rule: The Card Battle

Whenever a player attempts to capture an opponent's piece, both players resolve a card battle before the capture occurs. The outcome of the card battle determines whether the capture succeeds.

How to Play a Card Battle

1. The attacking player declares the capture by moving their piece to the target square.
2. Both players simultaneously place 3 cards face-down, then 1 card face-up.
3. Compare the face-up cards. The higher card wins.
4. Apply the outcome (see Outcomes table below).

Card Rankings

Rank	Notes
Joker (Sniper)	Highest possible card. Trumps Aces. See Sniper Rules.

Ace	Second highest. Beats all numbered cards.
King through 2	Standard descending rank. King (K) high, 2 low.

Card Battle Outcomes

Result	What Happens	Notes
Attacker wins	Capture succeeds. Attacker's piece moves to the target square. Captured piece is removed.	Standard capture.
Defender wins	Attacker's piece returns to its original square.	Capture attempt fails.
Tie (no Jokers)	The attacking piece returns to its original square. The turn is consumed. Neither player loses a piece.	Re-attempt on a future turn.
Attacker wins with Joker	Capture succeeds AND the attacker takes one additional non-King piece of their choice.	See Sniper Rules.
Tie (both Jokers)	ARMAGEDDON. Both pieces are removed AND each player removes three non-King pieces of their choice.	See Armageddon.

King Rules

Ultimate Chess has no check or checkmate. Kings are powerful, mobile, and mortal.

Kings Can Move Freely

A King may move into any square, including squares attacked by the opponent. There is no obligation to move out of attack, and no illegal moves based on King safety.

Capturing a King

Attacking a King requires winning a best-of-three card battle rather than a single round.

1. Play up to three card battle rounds.
2. The first player to win two rounds captures the King and wins the game.
3. If the battle ends 1–1 after two rounds, play a third and final round.

Note: The Joker rules still apply within King battles. A Joker win in any single round counts as winning that round.

King Capturing a Non-King Piece

When a King attacks a non-King piece, it plays a standard single-round card battle.

Warning: If the King loses the card battle, the King is captured and the attacking player loses the game immediately. Moving a King into a capture attempt is a gamble.

Last Piece Standing

If a player has no non-King pieces remaining, Joker and Sniper rules change:

- A Joker win counts as a standard card battle win only — no bonus piece is taken.
- Armageddon — both Jokers — also resolves as a standard tie with no bonus pieces.

Sniper Rules

A Joker is called a Sniper in Ultimate Chess.

Winning with a Sniper

1. The attacker wins the card battle normally (the target piece is captured).
2. The attacker then selects any one non-King piece from the opponent's remaining army and removes it from the board without a card battle.

Note: The bonus piece removal is immediate and requires no additional card play. The attacker chooses freely.

Armageddon — Both Players Play a Sniper

If both players play a Joker as their face-up card in the same round, Armageddon is triggered.

1. Both the attacking piece and the defending piece are immediately removed from the board.
2. Each player then selects and removes three non-King pieces from the opponent's army, without card battles.
3. Both players make their selections simultaneously — do not wait for your opponent to choose first.

Warning: Armageddon can dramatically change the board state. If either player has fewer than three non-King pieces remaining, they remove as many as they have.

Win Conditions

A player wins when any of the following occurs:

- The opponent's King is captured in a King card battle (best of three).
- The opponent's King attempts to capture a piece, loses the card battle, and is captured.

There is no checkmate, stalemate, or draw by repetition in Ultimate Chess. The game ends only when a King is captured.

Note: Standard chess draw conditions — insufficient material, fifty-move rule, and mutual agreement — may be adopted by house rule if both players agree before the game begins.

Dice Variant

If playing cards are unavailable, use dice to resolve captures.

Standard Dice

Each player rolls one six-sided die per capture attempt. Higher roll wins. Reroll ties.

- Rolling doubles on two dice counts as a Sniper win — apply Sniper Rules.

Custom Dice (D&D Dice)

Players may agree on custom battle rules using polyhedral dice (D4, D6, D8, D10, D12, D20). Establish house rules before the game begins, including:

- Which die or dice each player rolls
- What result counts as a Sniper equivalent
- How to resolve ties

Note: Custom dice rules should be written down and agreed upon before the game. The same rules must apply equally to both players.

Quick Reference

Situation	Resolution
Standard capture attempt	Play 3 face-down + 1 face-up. Higher card wins.
Attacker wins	Capture succeeds.
Defender wins	Attacker's piece is removed. Defender's piece stays.
Tie (no Jokers)	No pieces move or are removed. Turn consumed.
Attacker wins with Joker	Capture succeeds + take one bonus non-King piece.
Tie (both Jokers)	Armageddon: both pieces removed + each player removes 3 more non-King pieces.
Attacking a King	Best of three card battles. First to two wins captures the King.
King attacks, loses	King is captured. Attacking player loses immediately.
No cards available	Use Dice Variant.